

Study Protocol Summary

Study Title: Predicting NIMBYism in Austin's Housing Reform Era

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IRB Contact at Columbia (Morningside) If you have questions about your rights or welfare as a research participant, you may contact: Columbia University Morningside Institutional Review Board (IRB) Phone: (212) 851-7040 Email: AskIRB@columbia.edu

Study Purpose and Rationale Austin, Texas faces a severe housing affordability crisis driven by rapid population growth, tech-sector expansion, and historically restrictive land-use regulations. Recent housing reforms have coincided with organized neighborhood opposition to development using tools such as protest petitions, public testimony, and legal challenges.

This study has two core aims: 1. To empirically characterize patterns of neighborhood opposition to housing development in Austin using administrative and public records from approximately 2018–2025. 2. To examine the democratic implications of predictive tools that could forecast where opposition is most likely to arise, through interviews with key stakeholders.

Research Questions Primary Question: How can cities identify and understand patterns of neighborhood opposition to housing development, and what are the democratic implications of using predictive analytics to anticipate such opposition?

Sub-questions: a. What demographic, geographic, and behavioral factors predict whether residents will oppose specific development projects in Austin? b. How do different stakeholder groups perceive the legitimacy and utility of algorithmic tools in housing policy implementation? c. What alternative technological approaches could improve housing development processes without raising concerns about democratic participation and surveillance?

Study Design This is a mixed-methods, minimal-risk, non-interventional study that combines: 1. Retrospective and prospective analysis of existing administrative and public records. 2. Semi-structured interviews with approximately 10–15 stakeholders (city officials, neighborhood association leaders, housing advocates, developers, civic technologists). 3. Observation of public meetings (City Council, commissions, neighborhood associations).

Existing Data / Record Review The study will use parcel-level appraisal and protest records, zoning and site plan case data, public meeting testimony and minutes, campaign contribution records, and census/ACS demographic data. Identifiable information (such as names and addresses) may be used temporarily for linkage and feature construction and will then be removed from the analytic dataset and replaced with coded study IDs.

Interviews Interviews will last approximately 45–60 minutes, conducted in person or via secure videoconference or telephone. With permission, interviews will be audio-recorded and then transcribed for analysis. Participants may decline to answer any question or stop the interview at any time without penalty.

Risks This study is considered minimal risk. The primary risk is a potential breach of confidentiality. This risk will be mitigated through secure data storage, use of coded IDs, separation of identifiers from analytic data, limited access to identifiable information, and reporting only de-identified or aggregate results.

Benefits There is no direct benefit to participants. Indirect benefits include improving understanding of how opposition to housing development is structured and informing more equitable and transparent planning practices in Austin and other cities.

Data and Safety Monitoring The PI and student researcher will monitor data collection, storage, and analysis procedures. Any unanticipated problems involving risks to participants or breaches of confidentiality will be reported to the Columbia University Morningside IRB in accordance with institutional policy.